«N is a jerk» vs. «That jerk N VP» Expressive content is not invariably speaker-oriented and varies between predicative and ad-nominal uses

Expressive Content Across Syntactic Realizations

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THE MAINSTREAM VIEW

Claim 1

Expressives are attitudinal: the agent (S) has a negative attitude about the target

[[That jerk x]]c = λx : A^S in c has a negative attitude towards x

Claim 2

Expressives impose no Strong Contextual Felicity Constraint

Kaplan 1999, Potts 2005, Schlenker 2007, Tonhauser et al. 2013

MAIN FOCUS: ad-nominal uses

Claim 1 is mostly based on intuitions on expressives in ad-nominal position

That damn Kaplan was promoted	(Kaplan 1999)
That bastard Kresge is famous	(Potts 2007)
That damn bastard John	(Sauerland 2007)
That bastard Mark stole my horse	(Tonhauser et al 2013)

CHALLENGES TO THE MAINSTREAM VIEW

Against Claim 1

Non-agent-oriented readings are possible

Harris and Potts (2009)

Mixed-expressives convey both expressive and descriptive contents

McCready (2014), Gutzmann (2019), Frege (1892)?

Against Claim 2

Pejoratives in ad-nom and pred impose contextual constraints

Cepollaro, Domaneschi and Stojanovic (2020)

RESEARCH QUESTION

Can different syntactic uses convey different expressive contents?

Ad-nom That jerk N VP vs. Pred Mark is a jerk

HYPOTHESIS

Agent-oriented (AO) «A^S dislikes X»

Target-oriented (TO) «X is dislikable»

The content is evaluative both in AO and in TO

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METHODS

Predicative

10 Targets	*x è stronzo*	*x is [a] jerk*
10 Pos Fillers	*x è simpatico*	*x is nice*
10 Neg Fillers	*x è maleducato*	*x is rude*

Ad-nominal

10 Targets	*Quello stronzo di x*	*That jerk x*
10 Pos Fillers	*Quel simpatico di x*	*That nice x*
10 Neg Fillers	*Quel maleducato di x*	*That rude x*

Rating Task

Rating on a 1-to-5 points Likert scale the acceptability of the target/filler sentences in 5 different conditions

CONTEXT			TARGET
Sara, Luca and Chiara are at the pub with some friends Marco is drinking a coffee at another table	AO	Luca dislikes Marco	Luca says to Chiara: EXP 1 Marco is [a] jerk EXP 2 That jerk Marco is drinking a coffee
	INTER SBJ 1	Sara, Luca and Chiara dislike Marco	
	INTER SBJ 2	Sara, Luca, Chiara and others dislike Marco	
	TO	Marco is a fake and dishonest person	
	NEU	//	

1 2 3 4 5

Unacceptable — Acceptable

Exp 1 219 sbj [219; MA= 31.01; SD=12.51; 156f; 63m]

Exp 2 639 sbj [MA= 33.6; SD=10.5; 376f; 251m; 12others]

Selection Task

Selecting 1 out of 4 alternative paraphrases of the target/filler sentences

CONTEXT		TARGET
Sara, Luca and Chiara are at the pub with some friends Marco is drinking a coffee at another table	Luca says to Chiara:	EXP 3 Marco is [a] jerk EXP 4 That jerk Marco is drinking a coffee

AO	Luca dislikes Marco
INTER SBJ 1	Sara, Luca and Chiara dislike Marco
INTER SBJ 2	Sara, Luca, Chiara and others dislike Marco
TO	Marco must have done something bad

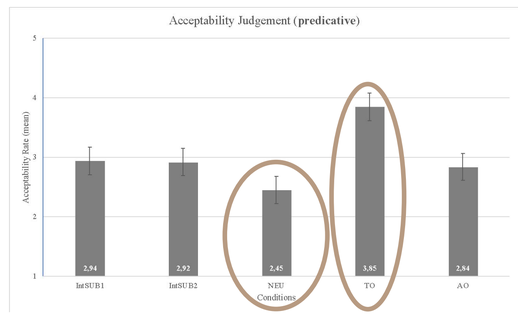
What does Luca mean?

Exp 3 112 sbj [MA= 23.74; SD=8.63; 90f; 22m]

Exp 4 106 sbj [MA= 28.1; SD=9.36; 36f; 68m; 4 others]

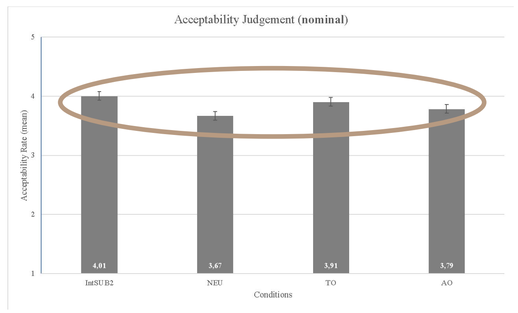
RESULTS

Exp. 1 Rating task – Predicative



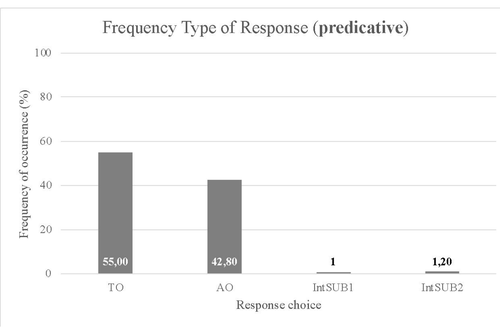
Non-parametric Kruskall-Wallis ($\chi2(4)=180$; $p<0.001$) + Pairwise comparisons

Exp. 2 Rating task – Ad-nominal



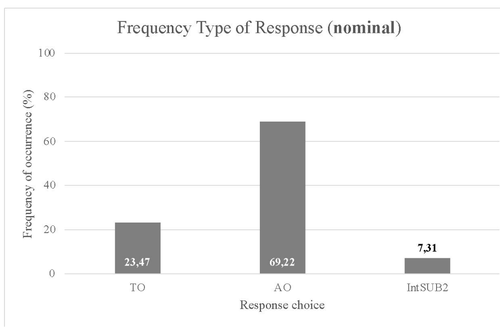
Non-parametric Kruskall-Wallis ($\chi2(3)=3.91$; $p=0.27$) + Pairwise comparisons

Exp. 3 Selection task – Predicative



Non-parametric Kruskall-Wallis ($\chi2(3)=843.35$; $p<0.001$) + Pairwise comparisons

Exp. 4 Selection task – Ad-nominal



Non-parametric Kruskall-Wallis ($\chi2(2)=525$; $p<0.001$) + Pairwise comparisons

DISCUSSION

Ad-nominal

As predicted by the mainstream view:

- AO is the primary interpretation for nominal uses (Exp 4)
- Expressives impose no contextual constraint (Exp 2)

Predicative

Contra the mainstream view:

- TO is the primary interpretation for predicative uses (Exp 3)
- Lower acceptability rates in NEU and higher in TO (Exp 1): predicative uses are sensitive to contextual information

Expressive content is not uniform and is constrained by syntax

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